

Writer par excellence

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Suresh Menon

At an impressionable age, I had two heroes in football. Besides those who played the game at the highest level, these were Geoffrey Green and Brian Glanville.

The latter came home on a regular basis over the years thanks to this magazine. Green I met later through his newspaper columns and his memoir, *Pardon Me for Living*, in which I read that he had been to the same college in Bengaluru where I had graduated from.

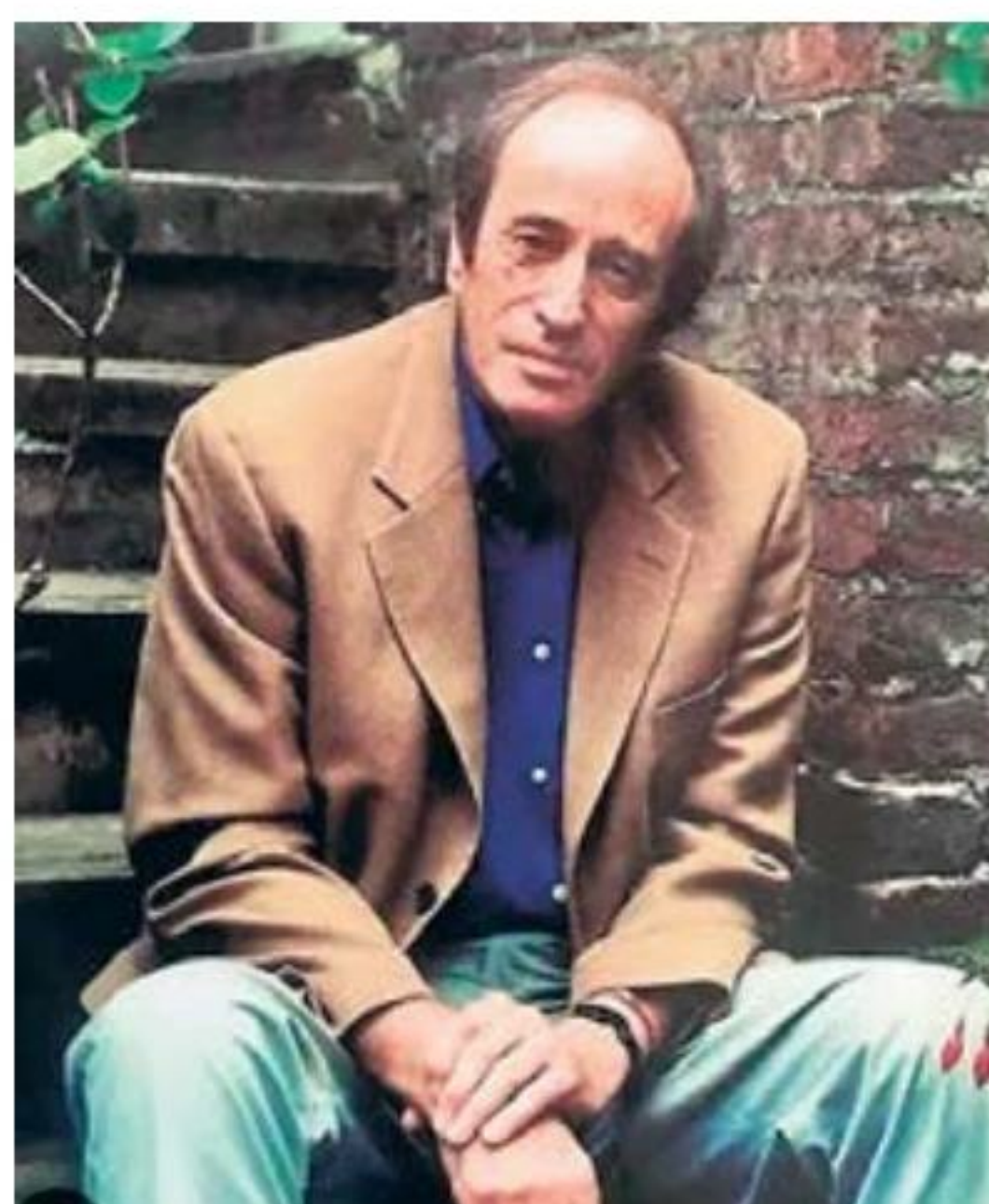
With the passing of Glanville (**in pic**) at 93, the great triumvirate of British football writers — Hugh McIlvanney was the third — have all left us.

When Hungary beat England 6-3 in 1953, Green wrote memorably of Ferenc Puskas who abruptly drew the ball back leaving the England captain Billy Wright, who had rushed to tackle him, charging past "like a fire engine going to the wrong fire".

It is a line Glanville quotes in his memoir, *Football Memories*, where he says of Green at his best was the best. There's always something special about a contemporary's praise.

"In his prime," wrote Glanville of Green, "he could ad-lib a match report effortlessly over the telephone.... Geoffrey's silvered prose flowed straight into the phone..." Funnily enough, that was my mental image of Glanville too, painted by a colleague of Glanville's in England.

This was confirmed by the *Daily Telegraph* which said of Glanville that "Extemporising to the copytaker, he would keep abreast of the number of words he had written with the help of a grid of boxes on a sheet of A4



paper, ticking each box off as he spoke." I find that quite incredible.

Glanville was probably the writer other sportswriters aspired to be, bringing to his work the discipline, the imagination, the charm that he brought to his plays, novels and screenplays. His two collections, *People in Sport*, and *Footballers Don't Cry* are must-reads for any young aspirant.

The former begins with the essay *Looking For an Idiom*, written in 1965, where he argues that British sports

journalism is waiting for "the columnist who can be read by intellectuals without shame and by working men without labour." This is the profession's two cultures as it existed then.

On the one hand, the popular writer (in the tabloids), he wrote, "knows that every piece is a selling out... a cruel limitation of his powers," while the so-called quality writer is "an alienated figure, writing for an informed minority when, given the wide reference of his subject, he should be speaking to the generality..."

Glanville said then that what was lacking in Britain (unlike in America), was an idiom "which will throw a bridge across the two cultures."

Thirty years later, he revisited the theme in the second collection, and said, "Notwithstanding the new wave of football writing, Nick Hornby et al, not much has changed."

Simon Kuiper writes engagingly on football, as does David Winner, author of two delightful books on the game.

But for consistently attractive and provocative writing day in and day out, it is difficult to beat Brian Lester Glanville's output.